

MIG-6

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-6

Age: 25

Gender: Female

Country of origin: Senegal

Host country: France

Years in host country: 3

Occupation: University Student

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I came to France three years ago to pursue a master's degree in economics at a French university. Senegal has deep historical and linguistic ties to France as a former colony, and studying here in Paris had been a dream of mine since childhood, something I had worked toward for years. My family made real sacrifices to help fund my education, pooling resources and going without, in the hope that I would gain skills and credentials that might one day allow me to contribute back home or build a meaningful career here in Europe. Arriving was the fulfilment of a long ambition, but the reality of daily life proved far more complicated and, at times, far harsher than the dream had led me to expect.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being judged by my intellect and my character rather than by my headscarf or the colour of my skin, being evaluated on what I actually think and do rather than on assumptions made the moment I enter a room. It shows itself when professors take my contributions in seminars seriously, engaging with my arguments as they would with anyone's, and when my fellow students include me socially rather than leaving me at the edges. Here in France, the particular version of secularism sometimes feels as though it is aimed directly at my visible religious identity, so inclusion, for me, would mean a society that respects my faith and my choices while still fully embracing me as a member, as a Frenchwoman in the making.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Yes, I have faced xenophobia, and in my case it is often tightly intertwined with Islamophobia, so that it is difficult to separate the prejudice against my race from the prejudice against my religion. My hijab draws stares and occasional open insults from strangers who feel entitled to comment on how I dress. A landlord once refused to rent to me the moment he saw me in person, after having been perfectly willing over the phone, and I have been followed by security guards in shops as though my presence were inherently suspicious. These experiences remind me constantly that, despite my education and my ambitions, some people see only a threatening stereotype where I stand, rather than the individual person I actually am.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The main challenge has been navigating France's strict and particular brand of secularism, which sometimes clashes directly with my religious practice and makes me feel that a part of who I am is unwelcome in public life. Academically, the French education system is rigorous, demanding, and quite impersonal compared to what I was used to at home, with little of the pastoral support I had expected. Finding affordable housing as a foreign student in an expensive city was also a genuine nightmare, and the discrimination I encountered, subtle and not so subtle, made an already difficult search considerably harder, doubling the obstacles that any student faces and adding a layer of humiliation to the practical difficulty.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: At the university the environment is genuinely mixed and varies enormously from person to person. Some students and professors are warm, welcoming, and sincerely curious about my background and my perspective, and those relationships have sustained me. Others are dismissive, cold, or openly prejudiced, treating me as though I do not quite belong in their institution. I have found real solidarity and friendship among other African and international students, who understand the particular experience of being an outsider in French academia, and that community has been a lifeline for me through the many moments of exclusion, both subtle and overt, that I regularly encounter in the course of my studies.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I hold my Senegalese and Muslim identity proudly and openly, wearing my hijab without apology and speaking Wolof with friends from home whenever I have the chance. I cook Senegalese dishes that remind me of my family's kitchen, and I stay firmly connected to my faith, which grounds and sustains me in a foreign place. At the same time, I have absorbed French intellectual culture and the language deeply, and I have genuine respect for much of what France offers. I refuse absolutely to choose between these parts of myself, to pretend that being Senegalese and Muslim is incompatible with being French; I am fully and seamlessly both, and I insist on my right to be so.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: French media often portrays African Muslims as fundamentally unassimilable, as a standing threat to the secular values that France holds dear, or as a problem to be managed rather than as fellow citizens and neighbours. This pervasive narrative makes ordinary daily life noticeably harder and fuels the discrimination I encounter. Very rarely are people like me shown simply as students, professionals, or ordinary citizens going about ordinary lives. This one-sided and relentless coverage shapes how strangers react to me before I have said a single word, so that I am forever starting each new interaction from a position of having to disprove an assumption rather than being met with an open mind.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: There were some university support services available for international students, offering practical help with administration and orientation, but very few of them addressed the specific and layered challenges of being a visibly Muslim African woman in France, an experience quite different from that of, say, a European exchange student. Integration efforts in France often seem to assume that

assimilation means shedding one's distinctive identity entirely, becoming indistinguishable from the majority, which feels deeply alienating to someone who wishes to belong without disappearing. More culturally sensitive support, the kind that helps students integrate while respecting who they are, would genuinely help people like me to thrive here rather than merely to survive.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: As a student without children of my own, I think about the future generation more in the abstract, but I observe it closely nonetheless. I see the children of Senegalese and other African immigrants born here in France, fully French by birth, language, and culture, yet so often marginalised and confined to the neglected banlieues on the edges of the cities. I worry about the cycle of exclusion that traps so many of them, the way that being treated as foreign in your own country can curdle into alienation and anger. But I also see young people fighting hard and articulately for their rightful place in French society, and that gives me hope for what is to come.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, France needs, above all, to reconcile its cherished secular ideals with a genuine commitment to religious freedom, rather than weaponising the principle of laïcité against visible minorities in ways that feel targeted and exclusionary. Honest education about the country's colonial history is essential too, because so many people do not understand France's deep and lasting entanglement with Africa and the reasons that so many Africans have come here. And real inclusion requires actively dismantling discrimination in housing and employment through enforcement, not merely celebrating diversity in a superficial and symbolic way while the concrete barriers remain firmly in place.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to complete my degree and go on to work in international development, perhaps in a role that bridges France and West Africa and allows me to use my education for something that matters to both. I want, through my own achievements, to prove that a Muslim African woman can excel intellectually and rise into positions of responsibility and leadership, against every stereotype. Ultimately, though, my deepest hope is for a world in which my daughter, should I one day have one, will not have to face the same prejudice, the same stares and suspicion and closed doors, that I have had to endure throughout my time here.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to newcomers is to know your own worth deeply and never to internalise the prejudice of others, however constant or wearing it becomes, because their assumptions are a reflection of them and not of you. Excel academically and professionally, because solid credentials command a certain respect and open doors that prejudice would otherwise keep shut. Build a support network of people who understand your particular journey, because you will need them. Stay true to your identity and your faith while still engaging openly with the new culture. And document any discrimination you face and learn your legal rights thoroughly, because knowledge is protection.